into the navigation act, but to no avail. Just when we thought that it was pointless to go on, I suddenly sighted a few small dust clouds on the horizon.

I asked the pilot to fly in the direction of those specks, and lo and behold! we came across the most wonderful sight; that of a whole regiment of armour blazing rapidly across the desert. Each tank was furiously churning the sand and leaving a trail of dust and tracks behind, as it wove its way through the sand dunes. It was hard to contain my joy; I returned to my seat and pointed towards the manoeuvres. The pilots, who seemed to enjoy the view as much as us, sharply banked the helicopter, and continued to circle around the area till we had a fill of that extraordinary battlefield scenario.

Thereafter the pilots were asked to return as we were getting low on fuel. Interestingly, on our way back, we flew along the axis on which the tanks had advanced the previous night, and where the 'follow-on' forces had consolidated the crossing over the canal. Here, we saw a bridge being launched. This unexpected event was a bonus. We hovered for a while at this spot, and finally headed for the Corps HQ. The minister and the army chief were quite pleased and satisfied to see these operational actions being undertaken by the troops in the scorching heat. Besides, with their vast experience, they must have also realized that there was nothing put on for show.

Unfortunately, we had a fatal Mig 21 crash during a ground attack sortie during the early phase of the exercise. We could only salute the gallant air warrior for making the supreme sacrifice. I was later told that the young pilot got so engrossed and mesmerized while engaging the 'enemy' column of tanks, that he lost a few milliseconds in pulling up, and unfortunately crashed in the sand dunes. We did not have any other fatal casualty in the entire exercise. Also, very few cases of heat stroke were reported.

It was 9 May 2001 and it happened to be my thirtieth wedding anniversary. When we left for the exercise, I knew that that year, Rohini and I would not be able to celebrate this special day.